on their own. They needed collaborators. So they planned to set up an Iraqi state which would be independent but tied to Britain. In 1921, they invited Faisal, son of Sharif Hussein of Mecca to become King of Iraq and head of a new government. It was Faisal who had led the Arab Revolt against the Turks in the war (see page 8).

The borders of the new state of Iraq were not yet clear and the British had to stave off attacks from neighbouring Turkey and Iran. Nevertheless, the new monarchy got off to a good start and was to last for over 35 years. However, the country was far from independent: the British kept control of Iraq's foreign policy and kept two airbases (near Basra and Baghdad). Above all, they controlled the oil: they did this through the British-owned Iraqi Petroleum Company which owned, drilled and sold all of Iraq's oil.

Key question
Why did the monarchy end in 1958?

The end of the Iraqi monarchy 1958

During the time of the monarchy, Iraq saw considerable economic development, education was improved and illiteracy reduced. But the country was dominated by a small number of big landowners while the vast majority of the population were landless peasants. There was widespread discontent. Above all, there was much resentment of foreign (i.e. British) control.

Key date
Iraqi army overthrew the monarchy: 1958

In 1952 the Iraqi government persuaded the Iraqi Petroleum Company to agree that the profits from oil would be shared equally between the Iraqi government and the British-dominated company. But the company still controlled production and prices. Added resentment was caused by Britain's role in establishing the state of Israel on Arab land. Furthermore, many Iraqis disliked the fact that their country was a member of the Western-dominated Baghdad Pact (see page 67). This had been set up by Britain, with Turkey, Iraq, Iran and Pakistan as members, in order to prevent the expansion of Soviet influence in the Middle East. Most Iraqis, however, wanted to be neutral.

In 1958 the Iraqi army carried out a coup which overthrew the monarchy and established a republic. The new government took Iraq out of the Baghdad Pact and persuaded Britain, which wanted to keep on good terms with the new government, to withdraw its troops. The Iraqi government also secured more control over oil production.

Key term
Baath
Means 'Renaissance' or rebirth of Arab power. The Baath Party had originally been established in Syria in the 1950s but its influence extended to several Arab countries.

In the 1960s the call for Arab unity won much support in Iraq. The champion of Arab unity was President Nasser of Egypt. There was considerable support, in Iraq, for the United Arab Republic which had been formed between Egypt and Syria in 1958 (see page 70) but the military government resisted pressure to join. Nevertheless, the **Baath** Party became increasingly popular in Iraq. The Baathists called for unity among the Arabs throughout the Middle East. However, in Iraq, they were mainly supported because they demanded a strong stand in the face of foreign interference in the affairs of Iraq.